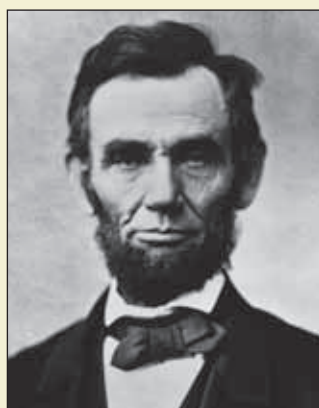


DIGITAL PHOTOGRAPHY

One of the most important things when it comes to digital photography of any sort is knowing and understanding your camera. Spend some time experimenting with the settings. Learn what each button does. It will put you in good stead when you need to quickly take a difficult shot and there's not much time to set up your camera.

For example, the fact that mobile cameras have fixed focus need not be looked at as a limitation. You can just as easily exploit this feature to create good portraits with an out-of-focus background! In fact, portraits were what phone



Taking portrait shots

cameras were designed to take in the first place. Who says you need an SLR and a fancy lens? The tips that follow will help you better take advantage of the features and settings of your camera.

Utilising grey cards

A camera's exposure meter calculates exposure and white balance (WB) using a shade of 18 per cent grey, or neutral grey as it's better known, as reference. Basically, if you expose a dark surface, the meter tries to make it 18 per cent grey by overexposing the image and vice-versa for brighter surfaces. The same goes for white balance, the camera tries to make



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Tips & Tricks has its own page numbers, and does not follow the rest of the magazine's page numbers. This is done to ensure that you can cut out and save T&T in a separate folder for later reference.

the exposed area a shade of grey and sets the colour temperature accordingly.

This is where grey cards come into the picture, literally. Have someone expose the grey card in the scene you want to shoot, using spot or centre-weighted metering, and the camera should give you the best possible exposure that it can in those circumstances. In fact, if you shoot a lot of images at that location, as long as you have one photo with a grey card as reference, you can batch process the other images using the first one as a reference.

For batch processing, depending on the software you



The same shot taken with and without a grey card

use, select the neutral colour picker and select the grey card from your reference image.



Manually adjusted white balance can give better results

Apply this neutral colour to all your images and you will have the best possible colour tone for those images. Most image management and editing software, including Gimp and Picasa, support batch editing.

Making your own grey card

You can purchase a grey card from most camera accessory stores, but the advantage of splurging on a good quality grey card won't really be worth the difference in image quality for an amateur photographer, especially not for people who are just going to use their mobile phones or pocket cameras. You can make your very own grey

card if you want to. Simply open up a new file in Photoshop or Gimp, fill it with 18 per cent grey and you're done. Print this. You can also chop out the image of the grey card we've printed over-leaf. Now this isn't 100 per cent accurate as the output is subject to the capabilities of the printer, but should be sufficient for most needs.

A simpler, and maybe more handy alternative, is to use your hand as reference. Take a shot of the back of your hand, one each under direct sunlight and in the shade. Compare the exposure to that taken with a grey card. You'll usually find that the